ALMA ALMATY MANAGEMENT UNIVERSITY

School of Social Sciences and Transformative Humanities

Tolyq Adam Institute

THE Awards Asia 2026 | Winner

ALMAU – TOLYQ ADAM-2026 INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE

THE UNIVERSITY OF THE FUTURE AS AN ENVIRONMENT FOR THE DEVELOPMENT OF A WHOLE PERSON

The Heritage of the Great Steppe and Contemporary Solutions



30–31 .10. 2026
Almaty Management University
Almaty, Kazakhstan

School of Social Sciences and Transformative Humanities

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The Heritage of the Great Steppe and Contemporary Solutions

DAY 1 — 30 OCTOBER

FROM THE HERITAGE OF THE GREAT STEPPE TO THE UNIVERSITY OF THE FUTURE

DAY 2 — 31 OCTOBER

DISTINGUISHED LECTURES & WORKSHOPS FROM DIALOGUE TO PRACTICE

Almaty Management University
30–31 October 2026

Dear colleagues and distinguished guests,



What does it take to build a university that truly serves both individuals and society? This question has guided AlmaU's development and shaped our thinking for many years. We believe that a university's success cannot be measured solely by the quality of its teaching or the professional qualifications of its graduates. Its true value lies in its ability to help people realize their potential, grow as individuals, and contribute meaningfully to society.

Over the years, we have explored leading international educational practices, introduced new approaches to teaching and learning, and continually reconsidered the university's role in society. Through this journey, we have come to believe that the fundamental purpose of a university goes beyond preparing qualified professionals. What matters most is the kind of people our graduates become. After all, knowledge and professional success do not necessarily lead to wisdom, integrity, or a sense of responsibility toward others. Universities must therefore nurture not only intellectual abilities but also the values and principles that guide how knowledge is used.

This search for a deeper understanding of education led us to the philosophy of Abai and his concept of Tolyq Adam, the Whole Person. Abai believed that human fulfillment rests on the harmony of three essential qualities: Aqyl (Mind), Zhürek (Heart), and Qayrat (Will). His ideas, expressed more than a century ago, are remarkably relevant today. As artificial intelligence takes on increasingly complex intellectual tasks, human judgment, moral integrity, and the ability to make responsible choices become more important than ever. For us, Abai's philosophy is not merely a legacy to be preserved. It offers a foundation for reimagining the future of education.

We sought to bring this philosophy into the everyday reality of university education. This vision gave rise to TOLYQ ADAM, an educational model that AlmaU has been systematically implementing since 2023. It places personal development alongside professional education, creating opportunities for students to develop independent thinking, a strong sense of purpose, and responsibility for their decisions. In 2026, TOLYQ ADAM received international recognition as the winner of the Times Higher Education Awards Asia in the category Teaching & Learning Strategy of the Year. This achievement demonstrated that ideas rooted in Kazakhstan's philosophical and intellectual heritage can make a meaningful contribution to contemporary global education.

For many years, we have learned from the world's leading educational practices. Today, I firmly believe that Kazakhstan also has valuable ideas and original solutions to contribute to the global higher education agenda. To realize this potential, we must look more deeply into our own intellectual and cultural roots, rediscover the wisdom of the Great Steppe, and connect that heritage with contemporary educational approaches. It is at this intersection of tradition and innovation that new possibilities for the university of the future can emerge.

With this vision in mind, we have invited scholars of the history and intellectual heritage of the Great Steppe, philosophers, educators, and university leaders from around the world to gather here in Almaty. We hope this conference will become a space for meaningful dialogue about the future of universities, the purpose of education, and new approaches to developing the whole person.

I firmly believe that the future of higher education will be defined not only by how far technology advances, but by our ability to educate thoughtful, principled, and responsible individuals who can use those advances for the benefit of humanity.

May our shared pursuit of this vision inspire new ideas, meaningful partnerships, and lasting change.

Welcome to AlmaU!

Assylbek Kozhakhmetov
Founder, president Almaty Management University

TOLYQ ADAM: From Abai's Philosophy to Contemporary Educational Practice

TOLYQ ADAM is an educational programme at Almaty Management University, implemented since 2023 to support students' holistic personal development. Initiated by the university's founder and president, Asylbek Kozhakhmetov, the programme brings the great Kazakh thinker Abai's philosophy of the "Complete Human" (Tolyq Adam) into dialogue with contemporary educational practice. Its central aim is to develop not only students' professional knowledge but also their intellectual habits, ethical principles, ability to make independent decisions, and sense of responsibility towards society.

Today, the OECD, UNESCO, the World Bank and the World Economic Forum emphasise the importance of critical thinking, creativity, emotional intelligence, adaptability, independent action and responsibility. In Abai's philosophy of the Complete Human, the deeper meaning of these qualities is expressed through the unity of mind, heart and will — aqyl, zhürek and qayrat. In his Seventeenth Word, Abai calls for these three faculties to come together under the guidance of the heart: "Bring the three of you together, and let the heart lead." His insight suggests that human maturity is defined not by isolated abilities but by their harmony. The mind guides understanding and judgement, the heart inspires compassion, and the will enables purposeful action. TOLYQ ADAM places this unity at the heart of contemporary university education.

The programme comprises eight interconnected courses. Great Books cultivates deeper thinking through humanity's literary and philosophical heritage; I and the World encourages self-understanding and reflection on one's place in society; Philosophical Dialogue develops a culture of thoughtful exchange; and Critical Thinking and Creative Writing teaches students to evaluate information and articulate well-reasoned arguments. Biohacking fosters health awareness and self-management, while Life Design supports purposeful goal-setting and future planning. Research Design develops the skills of scholarly inquiry, and Service Learning enables students to apply their knowledge for the benefit of society.

What distinguishes TOLYQ ADAM is that its eight courses share a common philosophical foundation and form a coherent educational system dedicated to holistic personal development. Knowledge and values, thought and action are brought together as inseparable dimensions of students' growth. Learning goes beyond acquiring established knowledge: it encourages deep reflection, the development of independent perspectives, deliberate choices and responsibility for their consequences.

Through TOLYQ ADAM, Abai's philosophy of the Complete Human becomes part of contemporary university practice, while the intellectual heritage of the Great Steppe gains new relevance within today's educational landscape.

THE Awards Asia 2026



In 2026, TOLYQ ADAM, an educational programme developed by Almaty Management University (AlmaU), won the Times Higher Education Awards Asia in the Teaching and Learning Strategy of the Year category. This achievement attests to the high international regard for an educational model developed at a university in Kazakhstan.

The Times Higher Education Awards Asia is a prestigious international award recognising outstanding initiatives by Asian universities in education, research and institutional development. In 2026, the competition received more than 500 entries, with 80 finalists selected from 17 countries. Finalists in AlmaU's category included internationally renowned institutions such as Seoul National University, Singapore Management University and The Hong Kong Polytechnic University.

The submissions were assessed by an international panel of experts representing Harvard University, the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT), the University of Warwick, SOAS University of London, Tohoku University, the World Bank and other leading academic organisations. AlmaU became the first university in Kazakhstan and Central Asia to receive this award.

The significance of this victory extends far beyond the success of an individual course or project. International experts recognised TOLYQ ADAM as a coherent strategy, systematically embedded in the university's educational process, grounded in a shared philosophical foundation and guided by a clear vision for development. In this sense, the award highlighted the importance of AlmaU's efforts to translate Abai's philosophy into contemporary educational practice.

This victory invites a fresh perspective on Kazakhstan's place in global higher education. For many years, we have studied leading international practices and sought to adapt them within our own education system. The international recognition of TOLYQ ADAM demonstrates that Kazakhstan can also help shape the global education agenda by offering new ideas and solutions rooted in its own intellectual heritage. Abai's philosophy of the 'Complete Human' is thus gaining recognition not only as part of the Kazakh people's spiritual heritage, but also as an idea of relevance to education worldwide. This is a victory not only for AlmaU, but for our country as a whole.

International Conference Concept

"The University of the Future as an Environment for Developing the Whole Person: The Heritage of the Great Steppe and Contemporary Approaches"

30–31 October 2026 | Almaty Management University, Almaty

Central Idea of the Conference

What kind of person should the university of the future nurture?

Throughout its history, one of the university's essential purposes has been to foster intellectual inquiry, broaden perspectives, and cultivate a sense of responsibility towards society. Although the content and possibilities of higher education are changing, this purpose remains as important as ever. Alongside professional knowledge and technological skills, intellectual maturity, ethical values, independent judgement, and the capacity for thoughtful action are becoming increasingly important. From this perspective, the university of the future must do more than improve educational technologies: it must create a coherent learning environment that supports the development of the whole person.

The conference approaches this challenge through a dialogue between the intellectual heritage of the Great Steppe and contemporary educational practice around the world. Abai's philosophy of the 'Complete Human' (Tolyq Adam) and the traditions of human development embedded in nomadic civilisation will be considered alongside contemporary university approaches to whole-person education. The central idea is to explore the relevance of this philosophical heritage to education today and discuss how it can enrich international academic thought and practice. AlmaU's TOLYQ ADAM programme and educational models from universities worldwide will provide a shared basis for scholarly dialogue.

Conference Aim

To bring the philosophical heritage of the Great Steppe into dialogue with international educational experience; to examine the conceptual foundations of the university of the future as an environment for whole-person development; to explore effective educational approaches; and to foster international research and academic collaboration in this field.

Key Questions for Discussion

The conference will explore the following questions:

- The person of the future. Which human qualities and capabilities will remain valuable as technologies and professions evolve?
- The heritage of the Great Steppe. What can the worldview of nomadic civilisation, its educational traditions, and Abai's philosophy of the 'Complete Human' contribute to contemporary education?
- The university of the future. How can universities integrate professional education with personal development? How should curricula, teaching approaches, and the university environment evolve?
- International experience. How are universities around the world advancing whole-person development, values-based education, and social responsibility?
- Research and collaboration. How can personal development be studied and assessed? How can joint research projects and educational initiatives be advanced?

Conference Participants

The conference will bring together leading scholars from Kazakhstan and abroad, philosophers, historians, cultural scholars, educators, university leaders, education experts, and researchers. Bringing together different schools of thought and academic traditions will enable a broad discussion of human development and the future of the university.

The programme will feature scholarly presentations, expert discussions, and opportunities to exchange experience. These conversations are intended to lay the groundwork for new initiatives to strengthen approaches to whole-person education, pursue collaborative research, and deepen international academic partnerships.

PROGRAMME

DAY 1
30 OCTOBER 2026

FROM THE HERITAGE OF THE GREAT STEPPE TO THE UNIVERSITY OF THE FUTURE

09.00–9.30 **PARTICIPANT REGISTRATION, WELCOME COFFEE, NETWORKING**

09.30-10.00 **OFFICIAL OPENING**

ATRIUM

Moderator

Timur Buldybayev

Rector of Almaty Management University

Assylbek Kozhakhmetov
Founder, president AlmaU

Sayasat Nurbek
Minister of Science and Higher Education of the Republic of Kazakhstan

Akerke Abylaikhan
Deputy Chair of the Committee for Higher and Postgraduate Education of the Ministry of Science and Higher Education of the Republic of Kazakhstan

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10.00- 10.30 **KEYNOTE ADDRESS I**

Prof. Joo-Yup Lee

Canada, University of Toronto

"Whole Person" in Turkic and Qazaq Nomadic Societies: Inspiration for the Person of the Future

A scholar of the history of Central Eurasia and the Turco-Mongol world. His research focuses on statehood, identity, and the political and social organization of post-Mongol Central Eurasia. He is the author of Qazaqlïq, or Ambitious Brigandage, and the Formation of the Qazaqs (Brill, 2016), which received the 2017 Central Eurasian Studies Society Book Award, and The Turkic Peoples in World History (Routledge, 2023).

PANEL I THE GREAT STEPPE — FROM HERITAGE TO THE PERSON OF THE FUTURE

Moderator
Renata Kudaibergenova, Vice-Rector for Research and Commercialization, AlmaU
Atrium

10.30-10.45 Prof. Marie Favereau — France, Paris Nanterre University | Online
"How Past & Future interconnect: Teaching and Learning with the Golden Horde"
A scholar of the history of Central Eurasia and the Turco-Mongol world. His research focuses on statehood, identity, and the political and social organization of post-Mongol Central Eurasia. He is the author of Qazaqlïq, or Ambitious Brigandage, and the Formation of the Qazaqs (Brill, 2016), which received the 2017 Central Eurasian Studies Society Book Award, and The Turkic Peoples in World History (Routledge, 2023).

10.45-11.00 Prof. Peter Finke — Switzerland, University of Zurich
"Sociality in the Steppes: Three Lessons for the Contemporary World"
Professor of Social and Cultural Anthropology at the University of Zurich, an economic anthropologist and scholar of Central and Inner Asia. For more than three decades, he has studied pastoral nomadism, social relations, transformations, identity, and institutional change in Kazakhstan, Mongolia, and Uzbekistan.

11.00-11.15 Prof. Zira Nauryzbai — Kazakhstan, Almaty Management University (AlmaU)
"Why Were Kazakh Khans and Warriors Musicians? The Role of Music in the Formation of the Individual in Kazakh Culture"
Cultural studies scholar, philosopher, and researcher of Kazakh mythology and traditional culture; PhD, Professor of Practice at AlmaU. Her research focuses on the worldview of the Great Steppe, cultural identity, ethics, historical memory, and cultural codes.

11.15-11.30 Prof. Mark Ingham — United Kingdom, University of the Arts London (UAL), London College of Communication | Online
"Joyful Educational Encounters: Becoming Nomadic Learners and Rhizomatic Universities"
Professor of Nomadology and Senior Teaching Scholar at UAL, and Co-Chair of the UAL Professoriate. His research explores nomadic and critical pedagogies, rhizomatic learning, student agency, creativity, and experimental approaches to higher education, drawing in part on the philosophy of Deleuze and Guattari.

11.30-11.45 Prof. Catherine Poujol — France, INALCO (Institut National des Langues et Civilisations Orientales) | Online
"The Historical and Cultural Heritage of Kazakh Nomadism and Its Influence on the Contemporary Citizen"
Professor of Central Asian History and Civilization at INALCO and a specialist in the modern and contemporary history of the region. His research focuses on political and social transformations, identities, religious change, and international relations. He is the author of more than one hundred academic publications.

11.45-12.00 Associate Prof.Ainash Mustoyapova — Kazakhstan, Karaganda Buketov University
"The Nomadic Heritage as a Solid Foundation for a Successful Future: Worldview, Principles of Life, and Values"
Researcher of nomadic civilization, cultural history, decolonization, historical memory, and Kazakh identity. Author of more than 70 academic and educational publications; his recent books include Nomads: In Search of the Lost Path (2025).

12.00-12.30 Q&A / PLENARY DISCUSSION
Panel I Participants
"What Can the Great Steppe Teach the Person of the Future?"

12.30-12.35 GROUP PHOTO
ATRIUM

12.35-14.00 LUNCH - HALL, 1ST FLOOR

KEYNOTE ADDRESS II — THE TOLYQ ADAM MODEL

Moderator
Assel Aryn, Vice-Rector for Academic Development, AlmaU
A600

14.00- 14.30 A.Zh. Sapargaliyeva — Dean of the School of Social Sciences and Transformative Humanities at AlmaU, PhD, Associate Professor.
"Presentation of the TOLYQ ADAM Model: From the Philosophy of the Whole Person to an Institutional Educational Model"

14.30-15.00 BOOK LAUNCH — TOLYQ ADAM
A UNIVERSITY MODEL FOR WHOLE-PERSON EDUCATION
Presentation of a book exploring the philosophical foundations of the model and their application in contemporary educational practice at AlmaU.

INTERNATIONAL KEYNOTE III

15.00-15.15 Michelle Hoffman — USA, Bard College, Institute for Writing & Thinking (IWT)
Online
"Imagining Writing in the University of the Future"
Deputy Director of the Institute for Writing & Thinking и Co-Director of the Center for Liberal Arts and Sciences Pedagogy at Bard College. Works at the intersection of writing-based pedagogy, the philosophy and history of education, and Liberal Arts; member of the IWT AI Working Group.

15.15-15.30 G. A. Muratbayeva — Kazakhstan, Professor at the Department of Pedagogy, Abai Kazakh National Pedagogical University.
"The Educational Potential of the 'Tolyk Adam' Concept in the Preparation of Future Teachers"

15.30-15.45 COFFEE BREAK - HALL, 6TH FLOOR

PANEL II THE UNIVERSITY OF THE FUTURE: GLOBAL PRACTICES OF WHOLE-PERSON DEVELOPMENT

Moderator
Assel Aryn, Vice-Rector for Academic Development, AlmaU
A600

15.45- 16.00 Prof. Pamela Pui Wan Leung — Hong Kong, The Education University of Hong Kong (EdUHK)
"Humanity Can Broaden the Way: Cultivating Values in University Students of the Future"
Acting Dean Faculty of Humanities, Executive Co-Director Academy for Educational Development and Innovation и Professor (Practice) в EdUHK. Her professional work encompasses teacher education, assessment for learning, multilingual and inclusive education, innovation, and the integration of generative AI into humanities education.

16.00- 16.15 Prof. Peter Finke — Switzerland, University of Zurich
"University Alliances: A Model for the Future?"
Vice-Dean for Study Affairs Faculty of Arts and Social Sciences, University of Zurich; Member of Una Europa. In the second panel, he participates not as a researcher of nomadic societies, but as a representative of institutional university practice.

16.15-16.30 Dr. Asmita Dani — India, Symbiosis International (Deemed University)
"From Curriculum Reform to Whole-Person Education: The Symbiosis Experience"
Dean and Professor of Academics, Head of Global Engagement and Partnerships (South Asia & ASEAN). Her expertise includes curriculum reform, multidisciplinary education, internationalisation, global citizenship, equity, and sustainability.

16.30- 16.45 Prof. Pascal Taranto — France, Aix-Marseille Université
"From the Labs to Society: HSS Innovation as a Key Feature of Next-Generation Universities"
Professor of Philosophy at Aix-Marseille Université and Director of the Centre Gilles Gaston Granger. He leads the development of LABΩ, a collaborative research environment focused on collective intelligence, peer review, and new forms of knowledge production, including the use of AI agents.

16.45-17.00 Daniyar Karabayev — Kyrgyzstan, American University of Central Asia (AUCA)
"Seventy Skills Are Not Enough: Liberal Arts Education and the Kyrgyz Ideal of the Whole Person"
Dean and Senior Lecturer, Faculty of Liberal Arts and Sciences, AUCA. His academic and administrative work focuses on Liberal Arts and interdisciplinary university education.

17.00-17.15 Aigerim Tarbagatayeva — Kazakhstan, Nazarbayev University Research Centre for Entrepreneurship (NURCE)
"Human-centered entrepreneurship for a sustainable future through Tolyk Adam philosophy"
Business trainer, life coach, motivation speaker and mentor; Head of the Association of Business Trainers; Researcher and PhD student at Nazarbayev University Research Centre for Entrepreneurship (NURCE).

17.15- 17.30 Q&A
Panel II Participants

17.30-18.00 CLOSING DISCUSSION — DAY 1
Assylbek Kozhakhmetov — Founder, president AlmaU

17.30-18.00 GROUP PHOTO
A600

18.00- 20.00 CONFERENCE DINNER. CULTURAL PROGRAMME
International Guests and Participants
Atrium

DAY 2
31 OCTOBER 2026

DISTINGUISHED LECTURES & WORKSHOPS — FROM DIALOGUE TO PRACTICE

09.00-09.30 **PARTICIPANT REGISTRATION, WELCOME COFFEE, NETWORKING.**
A600

Moderator
Aizhan Sapargaliyeva — Dean of the School of Social Sciences and Transformative Humanities, AlmaU

9.30-10.30 DISTINGUISHED LECTURE I
Prof. Joo-Yup Lee (TBC)
"Qazaqliq and the Formation of the Qazaqs"
An extended academic lecture for AlmaU students, faculty, and researchers.

10.30-11.15 DISTINGUISHED LECTURE II
Prof. Pascal Taranto
"A Case Study in Innovation: The LABΩ Collaborative Platform and Its AI Agents"
An in-depth exploration of a specific innovative research platform at Aix-Marseille Université.

11.15-12.00 DISTINGUISHED LECTURE III
Prof. Zira Nauryzbai
"Küy Is the Whisper of Tengri: Music in Kazakh Mythology and Culture"
An extended lecture on music, mythology, and the cultural code of the Great Steppe.

12.00-13.00 LUNCH - HALL, 1ST FLOOR

WORKSHOPS — UNIVERSITY PRACTICES IN ACTION
Atrium

13.00- 14.00 WORKSHOP 1 — ALMAU — Y. Zhiyenbayev, Sagatova Sh.B., Kruglova I.S.
TOLYQ ADAM — Practical Lab: Tools, Courses, Methodologies, and Opportunities for Adapting the Model. A practical introduction to TOLYQ ADAM tools, courses, and methodologies, followed by a discussion of how they can be adapted to other university contexts.

14.00-14.45 WORKSHOP 2 — EDUHK — Prof. Pamela Pui Wan Leung
"Values-based teaching, assessment, and AI for meaningful learning"

14.45-15.30 WORKSHOP 3— Symbiosis International (Deemed University) — Prof. (Dr.) Asmita Dani
Whole-Person Education in Practice: Lessons from Symbiosis. Practical approaches to integrating whole-person education into curriculum design, teaching practices, and student development, drawing on the experience of Symbiosis International (Deemed University).

15.30-16.00 OFFICIAL CLOSING

16.00 COFFEE BREAK

DIALOGUE PARTICIPANTS

UNIVERSITY OF TORONTO

ALMA ALMATY MANAGEMENT UNIVERSITY

University of Zurich[UZH]

KARAGANDA BUKETOV UNIVERSITY

inalco Institut national des langues et civilisations orientales

Université Paris Nanterre

香港教育大學 The Education University of Hong Kong

Bard

ual: university of the arts london london college of communication

amU Aix Marseille Université

SYMBIOSIS INTERNATIONAL (DEEMED UNIVERSITY)

American University of Central Asia

Notes